affiliation of INS Mumbai with the Maratha Light Infantry was a historic occasion. The ceremony was an apt reminder of the prowess of the naval exploits of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj and Admiral Kanhoji Angre. The domination of the west coast from Mumbai to Vengurla by the Maratha warriors laid the foundation of a rich tradition of valour enshrined in countless sacrifices of sailors in wars, was the essence of my address on the occasion.

On 30 November 2006, we got affiliated with the 20 Squadron of the Indian Air Force, nicknamed the 'Lightnings', located at Pune. The squadron's crest depicts three bars of lightning in conjunction with the Himalayan Eagle. It is one of the most highly decorated squadrons of our air force. This time the ceremony was conducted at our regimental centre in Belgaum, which included a joint Guard of Honour, exchange of trophies and an address by me and Air Marshal T.S. Randhawa, the commodore commandant of the 20 Squadron. One of our elite fighter squadrons, it is currently equipped with the state-of-the-art Sukhoi 30s. The highlight of the ceremony was the flypast by three Sukhoi 30 aircraft of the squadron.

Our regiment thus achieved the distinction of being affiliated with both the Indian Navy and the Indian Air Force. Both INS Mumbai and the 20 Squadron of the air force acquired the status of battalions of our regiment. I have often been asked the logic behind inter-services affiliation. My response is that unlike mergers and acquisitions witnessed in the boardrooms of the corporate world, our bonding is etched in the battlefields, where these very affiliations make the difference between life and death, victory and defeat. Our deep bonds are an example of close integration with our sister services, which will stand us in good stead in the years to come.

The fourth event was the 150th Raising Day celebrations of the 22 Maratha LI (Hyderabadis) at Hyderabad in November 2003. Colonel Pannu of the Hyderabadis, who happened to be my colonel military secretary when I was GOC I Corps, and later my deputy military assistant, made sure that we attended this event. This battalion has about 50 per cent soldiers who are Marathas, and the rest are